

salary, no matter what,” Jackson said with an air of finality.

“No one could argue with that,” Nick said as he recognized Jackson’s discouragement. “Jackson, as Christians, and especially as teachers, you and I have a responsibility to demonstrate the attributes of Jesus to those around us. In the eyes of our generation, nothing is as visible as the way we handle our finances, and—”

“I agree,” Jackson said, interrupting. “But God had to know our baby would need a lot of attention that would cost a great deal of money. Who’s to say this is not His plan?”

“I would. And I’d say it even if our roles were reversed and it was my son with the health problems. I believe you have allowed your circumstances to overrule your first commitment—to the Lord.”

“I’m sorry, but that’s easy for you to say because it isn’t your son, and you make more money than I do,” Jackson said defiantly.

“That’s very true. But I would hope that our faith is not built on what someone else does or doesn’t have, or on what they would or wouldn’t do in similar circumstances. You see, there will always be someone else who is better off than either of us and someone who has more money than both of us.”

Again Jackson said, “That’s easy enough to say when it’s not your finances. But I don’t see anyone paying our bills for us.”

“Perhaps that is not entirely true, Jackson.”

“What do you mean?”

“Several members of the school board and the faculty have put money in a trust fund for the medical bills you and Linn have incurred. We realize that you can’t meet all your expenses. We have been paying something on the bills for the last two months now. Didn’t you notice that the balances on your hospital and doctor bills have gone down?”

Jackson stopped cold. No, he hadn’t noticed. He had been so caught up in his problems that he had taken an antagonistic stance in relation to most of the creditors and had ignored all of the notices they had been sending. Linn had commented several times that they